BONEO PRIMARY SCHOOL · SPARK CENTRE · APRIL 2025

"What Do *You* Think You Know About AI?" — A Morning of Thinking Out Loud in the SPARK Centre

> Educator and author Karin Morrison visited Boneo Primary's Year 2 class to run a powerful thinking routine about Artificial Intelligence — and the students' big ideas, burning questions, and first encounter with Padlet made for a session nobody will forget.

BY KIERAN NOLAN · BONEO PRIMARY SCHOOL

Seven-year-olds, it turns out, have a lot to say about Artificial Intelligence. Some of it is surprisingly accurate. Some of it is wonderfully imaginative. And all of it is exactly the kind of thinking that great teachers live for. Yesterday morning, the Year 2 class at Boneo Primary School gathered in the SPARK Centre for a visit from Karin Morrison — educator, researcher, and co-author of the landmark book *Making Thinking Visible* — for a session that turned the room into a live, colour-coded map of young minds at work.

The Routine: Think, Puzzle, Explore

The thinking routine Karin brought to the SPARK Centre was Think, Puzzle, Explore — one of the cornerstone routines from Project Zero at Harvard Graduate School of Education, and a highlight of *Making Thinking Visible* (Ritchhart, Church & Morrison, 2011). Simple in structure but rich in purpose, the routine is designed to activate prior knowledge, surface genuine questions, and spark curiosity that propels further investigation.

Think, Puzzle, Explore — How It Works

A three-part sequence from Project Zero's Thinking Routines Toolbox that makes existing knowledge and curiosity visible before new learning begins.

01

THINK

What do you *think* you know about this topic? Share existing ideas and prior knowledge — right or wrong, certain or hazy.

02

PUZZLE

What questions or puzzles do you have? What are you genuinely curious or confused about?

03

EXPLORE

How might you explore further? What strategies, resources, or next steps could help you investigate?

The beauty of Think, Puzzle, Explore is that it meets students exactly where they are. There are no wrong answers in the "Think" phase — only honest snapshots of what learners bring into the room. For a topic as enormous and fast-moving as AI, this is a particularly important starting point. Karin has spent years helping teachers and students develop the habits of mind that make thinking not just something that happens privately inside heads, but something shared, examined, and built upon together.

What the Year 2s Think They Know About AI

Armed with iPads and Karin's encouragement, the Year 2 class added their ideas to a shared digital space for the very first time — using Padlet as a collaborative, real-time sticky-note wall. The "Think" section of the board filled up quickly, and the range of responses was a delight.

WHAT YEAR 2 THINK THEY KNOW ABOUT AI — A SELECTION FROM THE PADLET

- it means Artificial Intelligence
- AI is funny
- AI can help you find stuff!
- AI is smart.
- the agents in Minecraft are AI
- AI can do fund stuff and turn you into an animal
- ai is smart.n/nj.
- THE AGENT
- MINCRAFT

The responses reveal something important: these students already have a mental model of AI, even if they can't fully articulate it yet. The recurring references to Minecraft's agents show that AI isn't abstract to this generation — it's something they've already encountered through play. And the delightfully cryptic contributions ("minbbjvhioh", the long string of i's) are a perfectly honest reflection of what it feels like to be at the very edge of your understanding and still willing to jump in.

"Why can't AI be smarter?" — Year 2 student, Boneo Primary School

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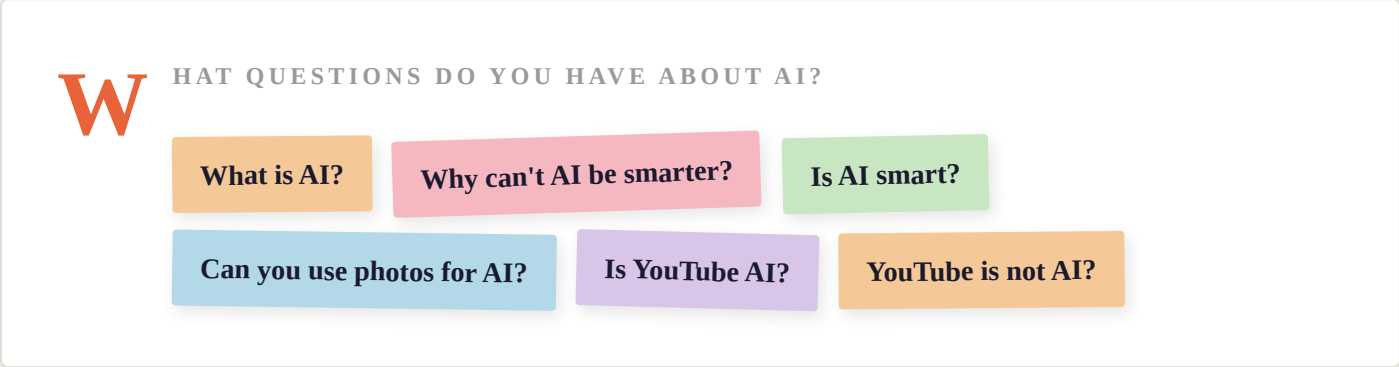
The Questions They're Puzzling Over

If the "Think" section showed us what students bring in, the "Puzzle" section showed us where their minds want to go next. The questions the Year 2s posted were thoughtful, funny, and in some cases genuinely philosophical.



"Is YouTube AI?" generated some spirited discussion — a question that even many adults would struggle to answer precisely. The productive tension between "Is YouTube AI?" and "YouTube is not AI?" appearing on the same board captures exactly what this routine is designed to surface: genuine, unresolved thinking that is ready to be investigated.

First Time on Padlet — and They Loved It

For every student in the room, this was their very first time using Padlet. The collaborative digital notice board — where everyone's sticky note appears on a shared screen in real time — turned out to be

a perfect match for the energy of the session. Students could see each other's ideas appearing as they typed, sparking conversations and a healthy amount of "ooh, that's a good one."

Karin then turned the same thinking routine back on the tool itself. A second Padlet board asked the class: *What do you think you know about Padlet?* and *What questions do you have about Padlet?* The responses were quick and precise — these students had just learned by doing, and they knew it.

WHAT YEAR 2 NOW KNOWS ABOUT PADLET

- put ideas on it
- write on it
- erase and draw on it
- Could the whole school use Padlet at the same time?
- Can I use Padlet at home?
- What else can I do with Padlet?

"Could the whole school use Padlet at the same time?" — that question, posted by one student, landed perfectly. It showed not just understanding of the tool, but imaginative thinking about its possibilities. That's exactly the kind of transfer that Karin's work is designed to foster.

Why This Matters

Think, Puzzle, Explore isn't just a warm-up activity. Used consistently, it becomes a habit of mind — a way of approaching any new topic with curiosity and honesty about what you do and don't know. For a generation who will grow up alongside AI tools that are still being invented, practising that kind of humble, questioning engagement is perhaps one of the most important things a school can offer.

Karin Morrison's visit to the SPARK Centre was a reminder that the most powerful learning tools aren't always the flashiest. A simple three-part question. A digital sticky note. A room full of seven-year-olds with opinions about Minecraft agents and a genuine desire to understand the world around them. That's more than enough to start something.

"How could you explore AI further?" — the question the students left with. Ask your teacher. Search it up. Try it yourself. The thinking has

begun.

About the book: *Making Thinking Visible: How to Promote Engagement, Understanding, and Independence for All Learners* by Ron Ritchhart, Mark Church, and Karin Morrison (Jossey-Bass, 2011) is available through Amazon Australia.

Thinking Routines Toolbox: The full library of Project Zero's thinking routines, including Think, Puzzle, Explore, is freely available at pz.harvard.edu/thinking-routines.

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